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**BORING FORWARD**
The BRO at work on the Nechiphu tunnel, West Kameng district, Arunachal Pradesh

## KEY PROJECTS BEING FAST-TRACKED

- The Siyom bridge in Arunachal Pradesh: a 100-metre-long, class 70 steel arch superstructure on the Mong-Yingkiong Road over Siyom river
- The Nimmu-Padam-Darcha (NPD) road section: This 300-km-long road axis is being black-topped as a two-lane road. It will be the third link between Ladakh and mainland India
- Nechiphu tunnel on the 317 km Balipara-Charduar-Tawang Road
- Arunachal Frontier Highway following the McMahon Line from Mago, through Tawang, Upper Subansiri, Tuting, Mechuka, Upper Siang, Debang Valley, Kibithu, Dong, ending at Vijayanagar near Myanmar border

5.5 metres, but eventually, given the "serious challenges to national security" in the recent past, gave a nod for 10-metre-wide roads for the crucial 674 km. But the human and environmental costs are real too—the HPC had noted 21 deaths due to landslides along the project's roads. The most spectacular fallout was the sudden and catastrophic land subsidence in Joshimath in January 2023. Many experts blamed the heightened construction activities around the town—including the Char Dham project roads—for the disaster. The huge tourism rush in the area, with the attendant building of hotels and houses, were also to blame. Soon after, work on the Helang-Marwari bypass of the project was postponed. It had earlier been red-flagged by the HPC.

### FOUR-STAGE CLEARANCE

The lengthy process of getting an environmental clearance involves four stages: screening of the project; scoping (documenting goals, costs, deadlines) to determine the terms of reference; public consultations to assess the impact on the local community and a detailed scrutiny of the proposal by an expert panel. Similarly, forest clearances also have two stages involving approval from various officials like the divisional forest officer, chief conservator of forests, principal chief conservator of forests as well from the integrated regional office.

Environmental/ forest clearance from the states is a must before the MoEF's final go-ahead and the various formalities of the clearance process at the state level need the close coordination of scores of officials. Experts say that non-availability of ground staff and poor coordination among the agencies concerned are largely responsible for delays. Often, states are loath to allotting land to the BRO.

Defence and strategic analyst Maj. Gen. (retd) Ashok Kumar, a Kargil war veteran, believes the army needs a huge infrastructure surge in border areas. "While fund allocation and fast-tracking of infrastructure have been given a push, delayed or non-availability of forest clearance affects the critical infrastructure needs adversely. This not only escalates the project cost but results in a situation where the army cannot move out tanks and long-range weapon systems to the forward areas." However, he feels that a balance needs to be maintained between military planning and environmental safeguards.

Lt Gen. (retd) Anil Ahuja, former deputy chief of Integrated Defence Staff (Policy Planning and Force Development), says the Forest (Conservation) Amendment Bill is a long overdue development from the perspective of national security, but that it is creditable that the government has not gone overboard in according blanket exemptions. Exempted areas have been kept at five to 10 hectares, which should be the optimum requirement. Also, it does not exempt security forces from carrying out compensatory afforestation that is mandatory under the green law. "This is the right balance—removing impediments to border infrastructure development and giving sanctity to safeguarding environment," Lt Gen Ahuja says. Kanchi Kohli adds that the bill needs a thorough debate in Parliament, informed by discussions with communities most likely to be affected by the proposed exemptions. ■